The loss of this alternative road to freedom has been much lamented, although it remains little comprehended in modern India today, but as Irfan Habib has stated, in the hanging of Bhagat Singh and his comrades, ‘we did not lose merely individuals’ but that ‘we lost rather an alternative framework of governance for post-independent India’.[3] When most revolutionaries had agreed to suspend action in support of Mahatma Gandhi’s non-cooperation movement, the disappointment that arose from the failings of ‘the national Bourgeois leadership’ after 1922 led to the widespread feeling that ‘it had betrayed the workers, the peasants and the youth’ and this is when the HRA was formed with its manifesto ‘The Revolutionary’.[4]

The Ferozeshah Kotla meeting of 1928 itself arose against the backdrop of the decimation of the previous revolutionary leadership, following the Kakori train robbery Case in 1925, when so many of them were promptly caught and hanged. Bhagat Singh took the opportunity to build on the foundations of the ‘Naujawan Bharat Sabha’ (Youth Society of India) but precisely when that body was formed is unclear. We learn from the account of Comrade Ram Chandra, who was a close associate of Bhagat Singh in his earlier years, that ‘there is no record of the Sabha available’ but that ‘from my memory . . . I say that it was formed towards the end of 1924’. In fact, he had ‘come across a file in the All India National Archives’ which ‘is Home Political File No. 27/5 of 1931,’ which lends support to this.[5] Ram Chandra played a key role in the formation of the Sabha notwithstanding his inability to precisely remember when it was founded. What he recalled fifty years later was that, ‘I was first to propose that the name of the [new] organisation should be “Naujawan Bharat Sabha”.’[6] His account remains the best of the Sabha from a witness of the events of that time and we are lucky to have it. It only came about because in 1975 when he was busily involved in making arrangements for holding ‘a freedom fighters conference in Delhi,’ Kulbir Singh, the younger brother of Bhagat Singh, came over to him and told him that a ‘greater duty’ rested on his shoulders than arranging a conference, and that was to write an account of the Sabha in the way that only he could. After five years of holding personal